

open source. Many people use tools like Mozilla Firefox and WordPress without realising they are open source tools. Mahiti explains the idea behind open source using these examples, and they quickly understand. By this time, they start associating open source with stability, the provisions for customisation and its ability to be reused/redistributed. "They were convinced because of their own user experience, and later, started approaching us asking specifically for open source solutions. With FOSS, clients don't see only the cost benefit, but also see a difference with an increase in stability, a virus-free environment, and an ability to customise and re-use old hardware," comments Rameshaiah.

Apart from serving domestic and international clients, Mahiti provides subsidised services to small organisations, and holds workshops for NGOs and students across the country, to increase awareness about how free/open source tools can be used for better performance.

Owing to a paucity of funds, NGOs and small organisations invariably look for low-budget but stable, and low-maintenance IT solutions. Mahiti serves this need, and uses open source tools and platforms to provide cost-effective solutions.

Though Mahiti promotes open source, it uses proprietary solutions as a part of its approach of offering the 'solutions' rather than the development tools. It does not believe in using open source at the cost of compromising the quality of the solution. Some clients insist on a certain level of reliability, replicability and clustering of the database. "If they want a high-availability database cluster solution, we use proprietary solutions like Oracle. In some situations, the client insists on a particular solution. For example, one organisation wanted us to work with telecom hardware that it had imported from Israel specifically for the project. The associated software was completely vendor-locked and proprietary. We considered the clients' requirements first, and wove a solution around it," Rameshaiah reports.

Nature of solutions

Initially, Mahiti provided open source solutions for portals, intranets, extranets and knowledge management systems on the Zope platform. It was not choosy, and grabbed any project that came its way. Mahiti gradually started offering network support, network infrastructure maintenance, mobile phone-based applications, micro-banking solutions, large-scale databases and data warehousing services. Along the way, it decided to focus on only four key areas—integrated Web identity (portals, social networking sites, mobile phone integration, integration of other enterprise software to the portal, etc), interactive mobile-phone based applications for Android and iPad, data warehousing and data mining (customer relationship management, customer profiling systems, etc) and micro-banking solutions and external memory interfaces. "It is important to know how to be selective and when to say 'No' to move up the value chain; otherwise we get stuck. Entry-level projects and clients who are not looking for a long-term solution, don't help a firm to grow. We look for a long-term commitment, so that we can

A rising graph

Mahiti's journey witnessed a turning point in 2007 when three more members, Chethan Elvis Das, Sunil Nalode and Vijay Rasquinha, joined Mahiti as part of its core team, and started contributing their specialised services. "Mahiti took its next leap. Each person contributed in a different way—Das took care of international clients, Nalode worked on rich media applications, Rasquinha took care of mobile and financial services, and I was focused on Python-specific development. This increased the management's bandwidth, and allowed us to dedicate key management resources to specific verticals," Rameshaiah proudly adds. This move also tripled Mahiti's revenue from Rs 60 lakh to almost Rs 2 crore.



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add value with our solutions. Some clients use legacy solutions that were built years ago and then start failing, as they are not upgraded on time. We say no to legacy solutions maintenance, unless the client has long-term plans for either a migration to a more contemporary solution, customisation, or further expansion of the project to current technology and hardware," Rameshaiah reveals.

Managing manpower

Being in Bangalore has been one of Mahiti's strengths, as it has an open culture and is a technology hub. However, maintaining talent remains a challenge. Rameshaiah elaborates, "We are maintaining low attrition rates in an innovative way. We engage existing staff in management practices, so that they feel proactive, and understand they are a part of the management. They are directly improving the institution, and growing with it. Second, we have tied up with premier IT educational institutions, and have created a supply chain to bring us a work force ready for production work."

What's in store?

Mahiti considers finance and interactive mobile applications as its key areas of growth, and plans to strengthen its offerings in these sectors. It is focusing on enterprise applications on Android, financial applications, and interactive end-user applications on mobile phones, and some projects are in their initial versions already.

A word of advice

Rameshaiah feels that people shouldn't be so fanatical about open source that they compromise on the quality. "First, ensure that customers get what they want. The choice of tools and technology is secondary. Don't sell technology, but the solution," he concludes. **END** 

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